Sectoral Policy Imperatives

Mining and Quarrying Needs a New Policy Approach

Mining and quarrying by nature involves disturbing the existing state of stability in the biomass balance. Mines in mountains and forests disturb the ecology and add to the fragility of the terrain. However, minerals and metals are necessary to meet the needs of fuel for producing energy or transportation and to produce goods and machines for consumption.

Balancing the benefits from mining of minerals and metals and the costs to the ecosystem and environment is a delicate task. The policy framework has to get this balance right.

A possible policy framework for developing and exploiting mineral and metal potential with the least possible costs to the environment might evolve on the following lines.

First, cap the coal production of India at 750 million tonnes a year from the current production level of about 600 million tonnes. Fast-track the allocation of coal mines to the private sector without any end-use restrictions and permissions to get them to work within two years maximum —it currently takes five to six years.

Second, small-scale mining and quarrying is inefficient and polluting. Develop mining and quarrying only in large enterprises, mandating the use of technology, minimizing surface disturbance and generating zero or near zero overburden.

Third, mandate the use of technologies to eliminate generation of pollutants and release of CO_2 or equivalent from power generation, even if it makes it costlier. Coal-based thermal power generation can be reduced over a period of time. Undertake a major programme to upgrade coal-based thermal power plants using subcritical and critical technology to superior technology in order to minimize the use of coal.